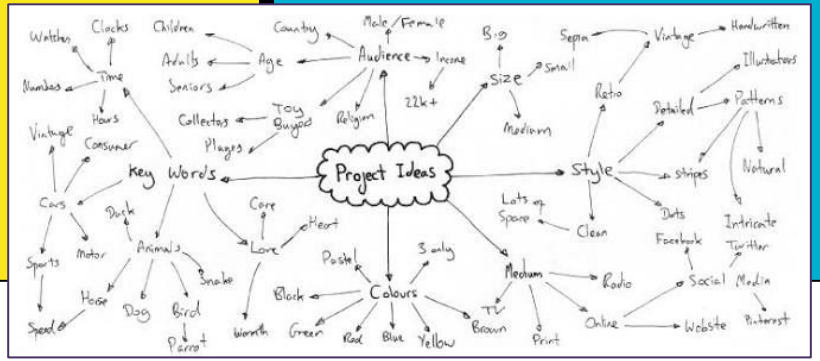
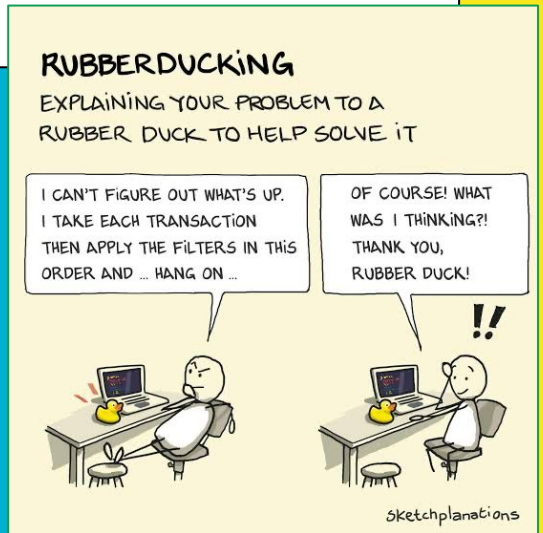


Using AI to Brainstorm!





What makes a good brainstorming session?

- Well-defined set of goals
- Understanding of constraints (of your problem)
- Diverse perspectives
- Time constraints
- Anything else?

Think and Share

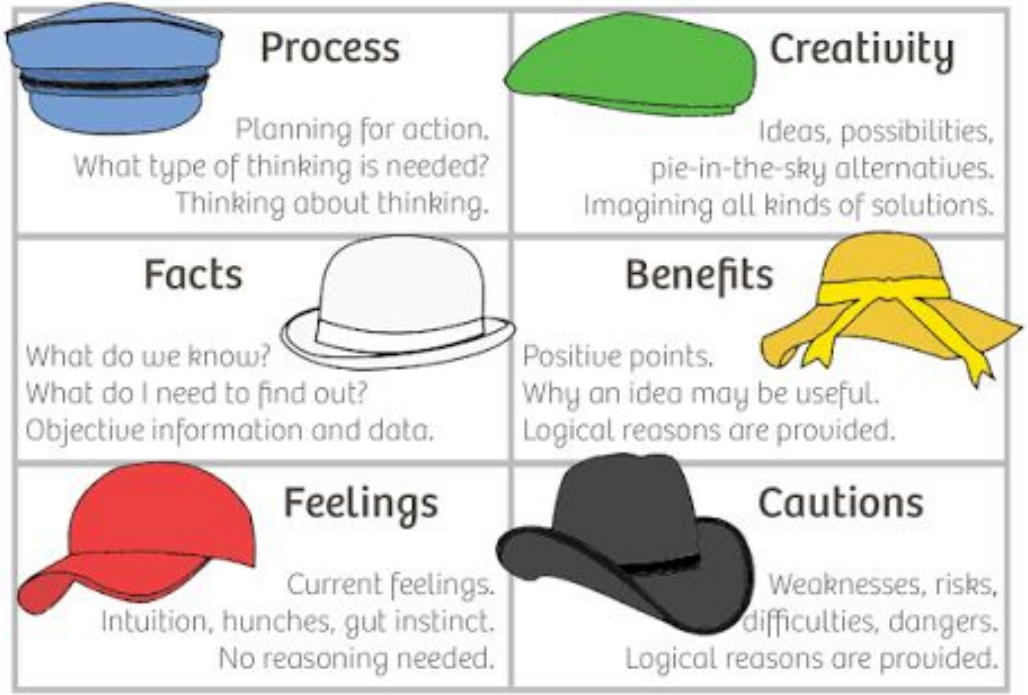
Let's imagine we are trying to solve this problem:

"You are a business owner for a currently remote-only company and want to make a decision on continuing remote work, moving to hybrid, or requiring mandatory in office time, which do you choose, how do you make the announcement, and how do you handle people wanting exceptions?"

What are some of the questions you would ask/ideas that come to mind to solve this? What would you do first? What background on this problem do you already have? What data points would you like gathered to make the decision easier?

Six Thinking Hats

Which hat do you typically prefer when brainstorming? What other hats could have been helpful to ‘put on’ in your initial thinking?



Consider this...

- Do you prefer starting with many ideas and narrowing down or picking one idea to start and achieving depth in that one lane?
- What are the things you want to optimize for? Impact, effort, clarity, etc.?
- Who/what are edge cases in your scenario? What questions would they raise that you may have never considered?
- How could I implement this same thing in a different way? Why did I not choose that?
- How do you know if you solved the problem successfully?

Think-Group-Share

Now let's get into breakout rooms and consider the same problem, what are some other things that come up for your group with more than one person tackling this problem? Did other people have information that you did not?

What 'hats' did other people wear that you may not have considered?

How can we port this over to AI?

Use AI to be any of the other ‘hats’ and to help verify what perspectives you are currently not considering after articulating your problem

AI as a curious observer

Don’t outsource your thinking, you are making the decision, not AI

Consider specifying that AI can only respond in questions as you attempt to clarify your thinking:

"Don't give me any answers. Ask me questions that help me navigate the problem myself."

Go into the brainstorm with your own ideas

Start with some background material to make your prompts stronger. AI works best with context, and since we are starting with a new problem, we need to give it all the context we have. This may require starting with a research phase before we even get to the AI interface.

What is the difference in the response from these two prompts:

"Give me ideas for a school project."

vs

"I am interested in [x] subject and I am in [y] grade, I would like to do a project in the science fair that specifically explores the relationship between [a] and [b], in a previous assignment we learned…. What are some ideas of cool projects that can help me explore this further?"

Iterate!

Sometimes AI can give you a response that unlocks a whole new idea!

A great way to work with AI is through iteration,

Prompt ↠ Review ↠ Tweak ↠ Repeat

"Those project ideas are pretty similar. Give me 5 that are completely different from each other"

or

"Combine ideas 3 and 7 into something new"

AI as a critic

You can also just ask AI to critique your understanding of the problem or potential solution.

"Here's my idea: [idea]. Give me the three strongest reasons it might fail, then tell me what I'd need to be true for it to work."

What to avoid

- Leading questions
  - AI can be sycophantic, asking leading questions on why your idea is good can reinforce an idea that may be missing something
- Trusting output before verification
  - AI is not always right, any data and sources should be double checked and use your own discrepancy for any claims or lines of thinking before incorporating them into your context of the problem
- Outsourcing your thinking
  - If you paste in the problem and accept the first answer, then you lost out on really thinking through the problem yourself. This is why getting background information yourself first can be so helpful!

Come up with a new problem and use AI to help you

Explore different techniques, what changes when you use any of the techniques we just talked about!

- Ask AI to be one of the other Six Thinking Hats
- AI as a curious observer
- Add more background to your prompt
- Iterate!
- Ask AI what is wrong or missing from your understanding

How did your thinking expand using AI as a brainstorming tool?

What is one way you will use AI to help in planning/brainstorming going forward?

How can you make sure you are getting the best out of that experience?